

Figure 4: Layer grouping

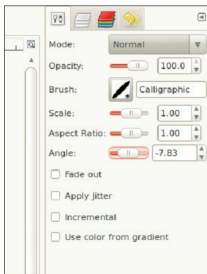


Figure 5: Improved brush dynamics

clutter and provides a lucid interface, which should increase user productivity and might lead to the GIMP snatching some market share from proprietary graphics editing software.

When you start it, version 2.7 defaults to the old floating-window mode. To enable single-window mode, choose the menu option *Windows > Single Window Mode*. That snaps dockable dialogues into pre-set panel positions—the toolbox and tool options to the left, and the layer-box and other dockable dialogue boxes



Figure 6: Layer modes overhaul

to the right. The GIMP allows you to drag individual dockable dialogue boxes from one panel to another. For example, you can drag the tool options to the panel containing the layer-box, and hence reduce the width of the toolbox, to give you more working area for the image you are editing. Or you can drag it elsewhere (see Figure 3). This results in a more complex, yet more productive and configurable interface for graphics experts.

There are downsides to the single-window mode, however. When you

open multiple images, the second image onwards is displayed at the top left of the editing area in its tab, instead of at the centre, leaving lots of empty space on the right and bottom of the editing area. Of course, you can use the four-headed arrow or the scroll-bars to adjust the position, but it is irritating. Another problem is that the GIMP fails to 'remember' that you've selected single-window mode, and again defaults to floating-window mode the next time you start it up. Worse, the floating toolboxes are positioned haphazardly; the docking changes and width changes to panels are 'remembered', but the panels are away from their old default position at the left and right of the screen.

I must note that previously, in version 2.6.x, the behaviour of the GIMP's UI in the KDE environment was quite peculiar. For some reason, the GIMP utility window wouldn't stay on top; as a result, KDE users had to go back to the GIMP 2.4 UI. I have yet to test 2.7's behaviour with KDE; I hope the developers have ironed out the previous issues with Kwin.

**Tabbed view:** The single-window mode also removes the huge task-bar clutter you suffer in floating-window mode, when working with multiple images. The row of tabs below the menu bar (see Figure 3) is a pleasure to use; it is reminiscent of Paint.NET, and each tab displays a thumbnail of its image. The tab list itself is fixed in place, unlike other GIMP dialogues or panes, and so is the order of tabs (you can't drag image tabs to change their order).

**Layer grouping:** Touted as a major benefit for high-level work flow, and a part of the proprietary Adobe suite, layer grouping is new in this release. With this feature, you can group several layers into a 'layer folder' (see Figure 4). This feature is very useful when working on complex images with many layers; it makes things less cluttered, and easier to manage.

**On-canvas text editing:** As promised earlier at the announcement of version 2.6, the developers have finally